

Swami Vivekananda and the Mainstreaming of the *Yoga Sutra*

CHAPTER 7

In Kolkata and greater Bengal, the administrative and intellectual center of the British Raj, Vedanta-inspired spirituality came to be increasingly embraced by India's urban elites as a compelling Hindu response to the missionary colonialism of British Christendom. Here, the founders of the leading Indian reform movement known as the Brahmo Samaj fused Nondualist Vedanta with the various currents of Western humanism, spiritualism, esotericism, and social reform that had been introduced there by Unitarian churchmen in the early nineteenth century. These leaders—Rammohun Roy (1774–1833), Debendranath Tagore (1817–1905), and Keshub Chunder Sen (1838–1884)—drew upon Indian spirituality and Western esotericism to craft a hybrid form of Vedanta, known as Neo-Vedanta, whose modern-day adherents include several New Age movements and Hindu nationalist organizations as well as nearly every twentieth and twenty-first century Indian and Western yoga guru.

As its name indicates, the philosophical foundation for Neo-Vedanta was Vedanta, which had long since become the predominant philosophical school of Hindu India. As was noted in chapter 2, the process of Vedanta-izing the *Yoga Sutra*, already well underway in the Puranas, had by the sixteenth century culminated in the nearly total eclipse of Dualist Samkhya–Yoga as a viable philosophical system. So it was that by the nineteenth century, a consensus had emerged among Indian pandits and intellectuals that the doctrines of all six schools were but complementary perspectives on a unified Indian system of knowledge, the highest expression of which was Vedanta. This perspective was given eloquent expression by Max Müller, who in his 1899 *Six Systems of Indian Philosophy* identified Vedanta as India’s perennial philosophy:

† The longer I have studied the various systems, the more have I become impressed with the truth of the view taken by Vijnana-Bhikshu and others that there is behind the variety of the six systems a common fund of what may be called national or popular philosophy . . . from which each thinker was allowed to draw for his own purposes. A friend of mine, a native of India, whom I consulted about the various degrees of popularity enjoyed at the present day by different systems of philosophy in his own country, informs me that the only system that can now be said to be living in India is the Vedanta with its branches. . . . The Vedanta, being

mixed with religion, he writes, has become a living faith, and numerous Pandits can be found to-day . . . who have learnt at least the principal works by heart and can expound them.¹

Published in the same year as Max Müller's survey, Monier-Williams's *Sanskrit-English Dictionary* also bore witness to this shift, characterizing the Yoga system in a Vedanta mode as "the means by which the human spirit may attain complete union with Isvara or the Supreme Spirit."² †

Carrying forward the legacy of the Romantics, an essential feature of Neo-Vedanta is its doctrine of Indian exceptionalism in matters historical, spiritual, and scientific. The two are intimately entwined, since, as the proponents of Neo-Vedanta have argued, all that is new in Western science was already fully mastered by enlightened Indian sages several millennia ago and written into the sacred teachings of the Veda. As for spirituality, while it is universal to all world religions, it is nowhere as pure and lofty as in Indian Vedanta, and nowhere as corrupted as in Western Christianity. The West, therefore, has much to learn from India, on both counts. Here the nineteenth-century Brahmo Samajis were working from the same page as the Theosophists and their spiritualist brethren, inas- †
much as both groups viewed spiritualism as an experi- †
mental and verifiable scientific enterprise. Also com-
mon to both groups was the notion that true religious
authority was rooted in rational faith and the direct

revelation that arises through individual experience, intuition, and introspection. The divine was within, here and now, rather than cocooned in a distant past whose traditions were only recoverable through institutionalized religion. Those institutions, now ossified and corrupted through priest-craft, were impediments rather than conduits to any true experience of the divine.

For all of these reasons, this new universal, rational religion, this return to the luminous life-world of the forest-dwelling sages who first received and revealed the Vedas and Upanishads, required new institutions—or, rather, a reform of existing institutions, which could only be realized through a return to the

† pristine lifestyles of yore. To this end, Keshub Chunder Sen began to experiment with spiritually based communal lifestyles, conceived as modern recreations of the ashrams of the ancient sages. Sen's early career in the Brahmo Samaj leadership had unfolded under the sign of social activism: lectures, meetings, publishing projects, and the founding of educational institutions.

† An 1875 meeting with the ecstatic hermit Ramakrishna, a living icon of Bengali spirituality, changed all that, with Sen turning increasingly to meditation and hearkening to the voice of God within. In this he was also influenced by the American Transcendentalists, whose writings were another important source of inspiration.

Against this backdrop Sen formulated the themes

† of what Elizabeth De Michelis has termed “proto

Modern Yoga,” themes that would reappear in the teachings of his most illustrious pupil, Narendranath Datta, the future Swami Vivekananda, as well as twentieth-century yoga gurus like Bangali Baba. Fundamental to this system was the assumption that the Indian mind had an exceptional innate capacity for Yoga. In Sen’s words,

We Hindus are specially endowed with, and distinguished for, the yoga faculty, which is nothing but this power of spiritual communion and absorption. This faculty, which we have inherited from our forefathers, enables us to annihilate space and time.³ †

While still in his late teens, Vivekananda stayed as a guest in Sen’s ashram. It was also Sen who first introduced him to Ramakrishna in 1881, and Sen whom Vivekananda would come to emulate in matters of both substance and style. A product of the intellectual and cultural foment of the colonial capital, the Kolkata-born Vivekananda was a man of his time and place, and in many respects embodied the late nineteenth-century synergy between European and Indian thought. Although he would repudiate the Brahmo Samaj later in life, he was in every respect an heir to its legacy, and in particular to Sen’s social ideals and Neo-Vedanta teachings. Other influences that shaped the young Vivekananda were his years of schooling under both Bengali and British mentors, who trained him in traditional Sanskrit scholarship but who also intro- †

duced him to the writings of Hegel, Schopenhauer, Darwin, and others.

Following Sen's death in 1884, Vivekananda and other members of the Brahmo Samaj's inner circle gravitated toward Ramakrishna, a Tantric devotee of the goddess Kali living on a Kolkata cremation ground. Although Vivekananda's relationship with this charismatic teacher was brief, cut short by Ramakrishna's death in 1886, it must have been particularly intense, because nearly all that Vivekananda did or said throughout the rest of his short life he attributed to his illustrious guru. Then began a six-year period of wandering, during which Vivekananda, wearing the robes of a Hindu holy man, crisscrossed the Indian subcontinent in a quest for wisdom, but also for the financial backing that would enable him to further spread the gospel of Hindu reform and social uplift, the legacy of his Brahmo Samaj background.

In the hope of raising the funds that had eluded him in his Indian travels, Vivekananda set sail for the United States in 1893. There, his powerful demeanor, charismatic oratory style, and gospel of India's spiritual superiority quickly attracted a following of "New Age" Americans already predisposed to embrace as authentic any teaching coming from the lips of a master from the East. Vivekananda burst onto the world stage through what was by all accounts a bravura series of lectures on Indian spirituality delivered at the World Parliament of Religions, held in Chicago in September of 1893. In the space of seventeen days, he thundered

forth a dozen times before growing crowds, dressed in his signature flaming red robes and pale yellow turban. An overnight media sensation, he quickly embarked on a series of lecture tours that would keep him in the United States for nearly all of the following three years. During those years, he would come to absorb many of the ideas in vogue in the metaphysical milieu in which he found himself, including harmonial religion, Mesmerism, spiritualism, and the occult. These concepts—many of which he had earlier been exposed to during his Kolkata student days through the Freemasons, Theosophists, Unitarians, and other groups—began to appear with increasing frequency in Vivekananda's lectures and writings, which he shrewdly adjusted to the sensitivities and worldview of his spiritually inclined Western audiences. A lecture at Harvard's Graduate Philosophical Club in May 1896 so impressed William James, the renowned psychologist of religion, that James invited him to chair Harvard's new department of Eastern Philosophy. James also introduced Vivekananda to his brother, the eminent novelist Henry James, who in turn drew the great teacher into the salons of the leading socialites of the time, in Boston, New York, and London. His circle of friends and admirers included Leo Tolstoy, Gertrude Stein, John D. Rockefeller, and Sarah Bernhardt.

In the summer of 1894, Vivekananda added practical yoga instruction to his teaching curriculum. He appears to have been driven by three motives. The first of these was popular demand. In the United States, Vive-

† kananda quickly became aware of a craving among members of his growing flock for authentic personal experience. For decades the spiritualist and metaphysical milieu had been clamoring for *practical* instruction in the techniques that could put them in touch with the likes of Madame Blavatsky's Himalayan Masters, or, failing that, their own transcendent inner Self. In such circles, Yoga was an idea (and a practice) whose

† time had come. Vivekananda's second motive was more far-reaching. In the months following his electrifying performance at the Parliament of Religions, he came to realize that his time in the West could be put to a dual purpose: in addition to financing the humanitarian work he had planned for India, he would also establish Vedanta centers throughout the United

† States. Accordingly, he founded the Vedanta Society in New York in 1895 and the Ramakrishna Mission in India in 1897: both continue to thrive to the present day. Finally, Vivekananda seized upon Yoga sans yogis as an ideal platform for his Neo-Vedanta agenda, as an ancient Indian science that was spiritual yet divorced from the benighted trappings of the Hindu religion he was seeking to reform. To his credit, Vivekananda's nationalism with respect to Yoga was Indian and not

† Hindu. In recent years, the tides have changed, with Hindu nationalists, as well as such self-appointed culture brokers as Subhash Kak and David Frawley, proclaiming the specifically Hindu roots not only of Yoga but also of world civilization and of all that is good in man.

If the Theosophists put Yoga and yoga on the map of late nineteenth-century urban Indian culture, Vivekananda did so for the rest of the cosmopolitan world through his 1896 book *The Raja Yoga*, which became an overnight classic. Written in two parts, the book comprises a transcription of Vivekananda's lectures and practical instruction on yoga from the winter of 1895/96, together with a free English translation and commentary on the *Yoga Sutra*, also transcribed from a series of public talks. †

Vivekananda's *Raja Yoga* marks a major turning point in the history of *Yoga Sutra* commentary. To begin, it ended a long hiatus during which, for reasons we have seen, no commentaries faithful to Patanjali's work had been written. This was both an opportunity and a liability for Vivekananda. On the one hand, he was freed from the traditional strictures that a flourishing philosophical school would have placed upon a new commentator: respect for a lineage of teachers and their teachings, attention to commentarial conventions, and so forth. He could apply his own powers of reason to the text, improvise, inject nontraditional elements into his analysis—and, following the lead of Rammohun Roy, adopt Western means of self-representation. But such opportunities also carried risks. Without a support network of living exponents of Yoga philosophy to fall back on, Vivekananda had few means to verify or corroborate his interpretations of Patanjali's work or its commentarial tradition. And so his success came at a heavy price: the severing of the †

Yoga Sutra from its original cultural and historical context.

† Most important, Vivekananda's *Raja Yoga* was the first English-language work to present itself as a "commentary" on the *Yoga Sutra*. Even when it diverged from commentarial standards, something it did frequently, its formal presentation—of a line of sutra followed by several lines, paragraphs, or pages of commentary—gave his work the trappings of classical models. The language of Vivekananda's translation and commentary—the language of Neo-Vedanta that has been carried forward into the many "New Age" contexts of modern yoga—was before all else the language of Western science (or scientism) and the pseudo-scientific language of Western spiritualism. As a culture broker, this was Vivekananda's means to modernizing the *Yoga Sutra*'s teachings, to making them relevant for turn-of-the-century North America. This, too, would explain the resounding success of his *Raja Yoga* in the West: it was, at bottom, a self-help book grounded in *Western* esotericism, but because it was the work of an Indian, its Western readership read it as an authentic work of *Eastern* philosophy, on the "Science of Yoga."

For all of these reasons, Vivekananda's *Raja Yoga* was something totally new. A bold, modern fusion of Yoga philosophy and Western science, religion, and the occult, this earnest and impassioned effort to make Indian thought accessible to Western audiences often succeeded at the expense of accuracy. Yet because of

his place and prestige as a pioneer Indian prophet to the West, Vivekananda's appropriation of Patanjali's work set the die for much of what has followed down to the present day. Mark Singleton puts the matter succinctly. What Vivekananda did, that none had done before, was to present Raja Yoga "as the *summum bonum* of the (authentic, practical) Indian spiritual tradition. Largely thanks to his efforts, yoga was re-fashioned as a cultural symbol, in harmony with the religious and intellectual aspirations of educated Indians—but also . . . shot through with Western influences and standards."⁴ More than this, Yoga philosophy was for Vivekananda an ideal platform from which to assert the antiquity and superiority of Indian science over that of the West, of Hinduism over Christianity, and, at the same time, to finance his many projects through the income that his lectures and writing on Yoga afforded him. Thanks to the brilliant success and prestige of *Raja Yoga*, the *Yoga Sutra* became the first work of Indian philosophy to garner a wide international readership. Once an orphan in its own land, no other work of Indian philosophy has ever known such a host of adoptive non-Indian parents. †

On the basis of his correspondence, we know that Vivekananda wrote his translation and commentary on the *Yoga Sutra* over a matter of months during the first half of 1896. Given his proficiency in Sanskrit, his great powers of memory, and a devoted stenographer to do the writing, this would have been entirely feasible. He wrote the volume while living in New York, †

lecturing from it as the writing progressed. It is clear
† from his now published early teachings on Yoga from
1894 that he had previously given very little thought to
the *Yoga Sutra*, and it is interesting to note that when,
in late 1895, he placed his order with an agent in Eng-
land for the reference works he would use in writing
† *Raja Yoga*, the *Yoga Sutra* was not included in his list
of requests. Rather, he requested a copy of the *Kurma*
Purana, the *Samkhya Karika*, two works on Hatha
Yoga (“Shiva’s Collection” and the “Little Lamp”), and
“any other books on Yoga.” In another 1895 letter, he
indicated that he was reading the *Yoga Sutra*[s] and “all
the commentators along with them,”⁵ but we have no
record of what his actual sources were.

Because his commentary bears little resemblance to
classical models, we may assume that Vivekananda ul-
timately decided against reading “all the commenta-
tors” in the course of his sixth-month sprint to publish
his *Raja Yoga*. Instead, it appears that he did a great
deal of free associating in his work, relying on his own
extensive background knowledge of the Puranas, In-
dian philosophy, and perhaps Bhoja’s commentary and
the *Samkhya Karika* for certain specific matters of
doctrine. His translation (actually, a paraphrase) and
commentary are written in the conversational, and in
some places chatty, pedagogical style of his lectures, a
clear break with the rhetorical complexity of classical
commentarial style but not so far from that of Judge’s
lightweight 1888 “interpretation.” Of equal impor-
tance for the modern history of the *Yoga Sutra* was Vi-

vekananda's idiosyncratic adaptation of the classical commentarial format. Like the classical commentators, he presented each sutra separately together with his interpretation, but unlike them, he did so without referring to the commentaries of Vyasa or any of the other classical authors. In the 120 years that have followed, dozens of self-styled commentators have followed Vivekananda's lead, adhering to commentarial format in churning out volume upon volume of non-classical and often uninformed opinion, drowning the twenty or so original Indian commentaries in an ocean of (mainly) non-Indian "expertise."

Raja Yoga is divided into two parts, the first being an introduction to Patanjali's eight-part practice and the second a translation and commentary on the entire *Yoga Sutra*. Part one, which comprises transcripts of his 1895–96 lectures, is a palimpsest of the many non-Indian influences that contributed to Vivekananda's understanding of Yoga philosophy. Here we see our missionary of Neo-Vedanta working to explore the possible meanings that Patanjali's work could hold for late nineteenth-century seekers. It is also here that we see Vivekananda following the lead of the Puranas, Hatha Yoga sources, and the pandit lore of his day in identifying the *Yoga Sutra* as "the highest authority on Raja-Yoga, and . . . its textbook."⁶ †

Although he refused membership into the Theosophical Society, there can be no doubt that Vivekananda was influenced by its doctrines, as well perhaps as by its positions on Yoga. Like the Theosophists, †

† Vivekananda made Yoga philosophy the keystone of his project of religious reform in India and the gospel of Eastern spirituality that he brought to the materialist West. In many respects, the Theosophists' and Vivekananda's projects were mirror images of each other. For whereas Madame Blavatsky had earlier grafted Indian terminology and concepts onto Western spiritualism and occultism, Vivekananda grafted terminology and concepts from Western spiritualism and scientism onto Indian spirituality and Neo-Vedanta philosophy. The Theosophical teachings turned out to be far more successful in India than in the West, while Vivekananda's lectures and writing have had their most lasting impact in the United States and Europe.

Nowhere is the influence of Theosophical spiritualism more apparent than in Vivekananda's discussion of prana, to which he devotes several pages in both parts one and two of his *Raja Yoga*. If Vivekananda did not take his leads directly from Madame Blavatsky, he may have done so indirectly through his reading of the society's 1893 translation of the "Little Lamp," one of the volumes he had ordered from London in 1895. In her 1885 *Secret Doctrine*, Blavatsky had begun to associate "prana" with both the omnipresent ether of ancient Greek philosophy and the magnetic fluid of Mesmerism and harmonial religion. The Theosophist Shrinivasa Iyengar, in his translation of the "Little Lamp," had followed her lead by explicitly differentiating "prana" from breath: " 'Breath' does not mean the air taken in and breathed out, but the Prana, i.e., the magnetic cur-

rent of breath.”⁷ Vivekananda took matters several steps further, making prana and akasha (a Sanskrit term often translated as “ether”) the foundations of a novel metaphysics that owed more to Aristotle and Mesmer than to ancient Indian traditions.

By recasting prana in the way he did, Vivekananda was able to simultaneously dismiss what he called the “queer breathing exercises of the Hatha Yoga” as inauthentic, and repackage Western spiritualism as a brand of Raja Yoga. Forcing such straightforward Indian concepts into a Western occultist mold was, as Elizabeth De Michelis has shown, a deliberate strategy on his part. Like his American audiences, Vivekananda was influenced by the Theosophists and deeply engaged in the alternative healing traditions that characterized the “New Thought” of the period. In his expansive reworking of the yogic principles and practices of breath control, we see him speaking their language, a language that many modern yoga gurus continue to speak. Unaware of how fast and loose Vivekananda was playing with these Indian philosophical concepts, some of the great scientific minds of his time were highly impressed by his ability to shuttle between modern “Eastern” spirituality and modern Western scientific theory. Nikola Tesla, who was introduced to Vivekananda by Sarah Bernhardt, would cite him in his pioneering research on electromagnetism, precisely on the topics of prana and akasha.

Like the majority of nonspecialist readers of the *Yoga Sutra*, Vivekananda was unclear about the his-

- tory of the interactions between the distinct fields of Raja Yoga, Hatha Yoga, and Tantric Yoga. Time and again, in both parts of his book, he refers to features of the yogic body—the three major channels, the seven chakras or lotuses—that have no place in the *Yoga Sutra* but which are leitmotifs of Tantric Yoga. A schematic drawing of the same yogic body, inserted into the “Psychic Prana” chapter of *Raja Yoga*, is entirely based on Hatha Yoga traditions. So too, his explanation of the breathing exercises of pranayama—the fourth component of the eight-part practice—as well as the awakening of the serpentine energy called kundalini, and the effects of holding the breath for extended durations, are found in the Puranas, Tantras, and Hatha Yoga works, but not in the *Yoga Sutra*.
- † In spite of this, Vivekananda missed no occasion to denigrate Hatha Yoga as inferior and counterproductive to the practice of his so-called Raja Yoga. There can be little doubt that his negative evaluation of Hatha Yoga flowed from its identification with the practices of India’s yogis. For the many reasons we have already seen, the yogi lifestyle epitomized the benighted, corrupted forms of Hinduism that Vivekananda, as an heir to the Romantics, was attempting to reform. Like them, he was seeking to recover the pristine origins of the Hindu religion—“nuggets of gold and truth”⁸ as he called them, from the “masses of superstition” under which they were buried. In this, Vivekananda joined a chorus of voices that viewed India’s yogis as the modern-day bearers of the ancient tra-

dition of the true Yoga, Raja Yoga, but who had, out of ignorance and perfidy, allowed it to become eclipsed by Hatha practices and antisocial ways. This he states in no uncertain terms in his first chapter of part one:

Mystery-mongering weakens the human brain. It †
has well-nigh destroyed Yoga—one of the grand-
est of sciences. From the time it was discovered,
more than four thousand years ago, Yoga was per-
fectly delineated, formulated, and preached in
India. It is a striking fact that the more modern the
commentator the greater the mistakes he makes,
while the more ancient the writer the more ratio-
nal he is. Most of the modern writers talk of all
sorts of mystery. Thus Yoga fell into the hands of a
few persons who made it a secret, instead of letting
the full blaze of daylight and reason fall upon it.
They did so that they might have the powers to
themselves.⁹

In fairness to Vivekananda, it should be noted that his †
own guru Ramakrishna had been ambiguous in his ap-
preciation of Hatha Yoga. On the one hand, he had
praised Raja as superior to Hatha, yet, when describing
the actual practice of yoga, he spoke in terms of awak-
ening and raising the kundalini through the lotuses or
chakras. Another of Vivekananda's likely influences
was one of his mentors from his student days in Kolk-
ata. This was the Bengali intellectual Ishwar Chandra †
Vidyasagar, who shared his own 1853 English-language
translation of Madhava's "Compendium" with the

young Vivekananda. As we have seen, this work, which was held in great esteem among Indian reformers, featured in its long chapter on “Patanjali’s System” several elements of Hatha and Tantric Yoga. Another of Vidyasagar’s projects would also have a powerful impact on the modern history of Yoga philosophy. In 1850 a report he submitted to the secretary to the Council of Education in Kolkata requested that the Sanskrit College there broaden its instruction in philosophy to include, among other texts, the *Yoga Sutra*. It was here that several decades later Hariharananda Aranya, arguably the most important Indian *Yoga Sutra* commentator of the twentieth century, first received instruction in Yoga philosophy.

- † Vivekananda’s reliance on the Puranas over and against the *Yoga Sutra* itself is exemplified in the use he makes of the *Kurma Purana*, inasmuch as he concludes part one of his *Raja Yoga* with “a summary of Raja-yoga freely translated from the *Kurma Purana*.” Here again we see Vivekananda presenting data culled from a hodgepodge of sources as “Raja Yoga” and identifying that Raja Yoga with Patanjali’s teachings. Vivekananda’s expurgated version of the *Kurma*’s chapter on the eight-part practice is noteworthy on a number of points. To begin, the *Kurma*’s account, while paying lip service to the techniques of the eight-part practice (but without mentioning either Patanjali or the *Yoga Sutra*), is essentially a guide to yogic meditation on Shiva in his multiple aspects and forms, culminating in either identity or union with the great God. In this re-

spect, it is like several other Puranic accounts of the Yoga system: a summary of the eight-part practice and a definition of Yoga as union with God. When one looks at the unexpurgated *Kurma* chapter, however, one finds that only thirty-four of its 146 verses treat of the eight-part practice or, for that matter, any form of yoga that could possibly be identified with the “Raja Yoga” of the *Yoga Sutra*.

In fact, the term that the *Kurma* uses for this type of yoga is not “Raja,” but rather “Abhava” (“Absence,” † “Negation”), which it casts as a markedly inferior form of practice in comparison with the Mahayoga (“Great Yoga”) of identification with Shiva. At one point, the *Kurma* identifies this latter form of yoga as “Pashu- † pata Yoga,” the yoga of the ancient Pashupata order of Shaiva ascetics who were the forerunners of the widely despised yogis. Vivekananda translates the chapter in a highly selective way, by leaving out nearly every verse not devoted to the eight-part practice—as well as every one of the chapter’s frequent references to Shiva—and by inserting near the end of his chapter a † quote from the *Bhagavad Gita*.

In his introduction to part two of *Raja Yoga*, in which he seeks to present a sweeping overview of the *Yoga Sutra* in its broader philosophical context, we once again see Vivekananda writing in the familiar Vedanta mode: “The goal is to manifest this Divinity † within, by controlling nature, external and internal.”¹⁰ In the balance of part two, the remarks Vivekananda offers in his commentary on the *Yoga Sutra* aphorisms

are generally respectful of the text. At times, however, his interpretations are highly forced, breaking with commentarial tradition even as they allow him to underscore the superiority and scientific nature of ancient Hindu thought. A lucid study by Dermot Killingley of two of the opening verses of Patanjali's fourth chapter shall serve as a case in point. A straightforward translation of the terse Sanskrit of those sutras reads as follows:

Change of species [results] from the filling in of
their [inherent] natures. (4.2)

The efficient cause is not the motor of these
[changes of their inherent] natures: only the
piercing of the barrier [takes place] through it,
as in the case of the farmer. (4.3)

Vivekananda's English "adaptation" of these sutras was quite different:

The change into another species is by the filling in
of Nature. (4.2)

Good and bad deeds are not the direct cause in the
transformations of Nature, but they act as
breakers of obstacles to the evolutions of Na-
ture: as a farmer breaks the obstacles to the
course of water, which then runs down of its
own nature. (4.3)

In his commentary on these verses, Vivekananda betrays the intention behind his insertion of the word "evolutions":

So all progress and power are already in every man; †
 perfection is man's nature. . . . If anyone can take
 the bar off, in rushes Nature. . . . It is Nature that is
 driving us towards perfection, and eventually she
 will bring everyone there. . . . Today the evolution
 theory of the ancient Yogis will be better under-
 stood in the light of modern research. And yet the
 theory of the Yogis is a better explanation. The . . .
 causes of evolution advanced by the moderns . . .
 are inadequate. . . . But the great ancient evolution-
 ist, Patanjali, declares that the true secret of evolu-
 tion is the manifestation of the perfection, which is
 already in every being. . . . So in man there is the
 potential god, kept in by the locks and bars of ig-
 norance. When knowledge breaks these bars, the
 god becomes manifest.¹¹

Contrary to Vivekananda's reading, these sutras were
 not concerned with collective species but rather with
 individual persons who stand an equal chance of rising
 or falling along the great chain of being when they are
 reborn. Vivekananda, however, chose to view them as
 evocations of a straight-line evolution of the human
 race toward an innate preselected perfection. This was
 a spiritual process: there was a Spirit present in all be- †
 ings, and the full self-manifestation of that divine
 Spirit, that transcendent Self, was the teleological pur-
 pose of evolution. The Brahmo Samaj position that the
 scientific knowledge of the ancient Hindus had yet to
 be fathomed by Western science is also clearly present

here, in Vivekananda's argument for the superiority of Patanjali's evolutionary theory over that of Darwin. Modern yoga gurus who have followed Vivekananda's lead include Bhagwan Rajneesh (a.k.a. Osho), who in 1984 credited Patanjali with having, "for the first time in the history of humanity . . . brought religion to the state of science: he made religion a science; bare laws; no belief is needed."¹²

† Vivekananda was so taken with his readings of these two sutras that he repeated them on four different occasions. On one of these, he identified evolutionary progress with the enhanced control of the body attained through Yoga. On another, he pushed his argument further, maintaining that this doctrine of inherent perfection is "the great difference between Eastern and Western thought," even as he attacked "such awful doctrines as that we are all born sinners."¹³ As powerful a rhetorical position as this may have been for his late nineteenth-century audiences, it was utterly at odds with the original purport of these sutras and classical Indian commentaries on their subject. Here, an overview of that history is instructive, because it offers a window into the worldviews and *modus operandi* of India's classical schoolmen. As we have seen, these commentators approached their subjects in much the same way as the judicial review process. This was not the place for flashy innovation; rather, the goal was to demonstrate how the concept under examination fit into the broader picture of universal knowledge.

By interpreting these two sutras in the way he did, Vivekananda excised them from their context, in this case verses one to six of the fourth chapter, which were treated as a coherent whole by both Patanjali and his classical commentators. Patanjali introduces his discussion in the first sutra, which posits that the supernatural powers of Yoga that had been the subject of the preceding chapter arise through a number of transformations, of which the most common is rebirth. If a man is reborn as a bird, he suddenly becomes possessed of a power of flight that he had not enjoyed in his previous life. However, Patanjali and his commentators also hypothesized that one could also be reborn as a *human* possessed of the supernatural powers of flight and so forth, due to the effects of one's karma, one's prior acts. The two verses that follow, the verses upon which Vivekananda based his commentary on "evolution," explain just how such transformations or reconfigurations—from one body to another—occur, not only through rebirth but also, in rare cases, within the course of a single lifetime.

The classical commentators, beginning with Vyasa, provide examples from Hindu mythology to elucidate these verses, evoking the brahmin Nandishvara who, through his pious acts, was changed into a god while still alive, and a king named Nahusha whose overweening pride instantaneously transformed him into a serpent. Just as when a barrier has been lifted or broken to allow water to move from one field to another, they tell us, the merits or demerits of human acts and inten-

tions can remove the obstacles that stand in the way of their *immediate* transformation into other types of beings. The merits and demerits are not the direct or efficient cause of the changes any more than the farmer who pierces the barrier of an irrigation canal himself causes the water to flow. Rather, in the same way that he simply unblocks the sole impediment to the force of gravity upon the mass of water, so too a creature's merits and demerits remove the obstacles that stand in the way of its change into a member of another species.

The three verses that follow—*Yoga Sutra* 4.4–6—concern the yogi who is capable of creating and assuming several bodies simultaneously, even as he continues to inhabit his own body. For both Patanjali and the classical commentators, the connection was clear: the yogi possessed of such supernatural powers is a special case of the transformation of one type of creature into another, in this case from a singular being (the yogi) into multiple beings (the many bodies he assumes or inhabits). Under such circumstances, the question that arises, and which Patanjali next answers, concerns the relationship between the mind of the meditating yogi and the many bodies he inhabits: do they have individual minds or one mind? And, if the latter, is that one mind the same as or different from the mind of the yogi who inhabits these other bodies even as he remains “himself”? Patanjali's response is that while each constructed body is possessed of its own mind, those multiple minds remain subject to the yogi's own ego

and will. By way of example, Bhoja evokes the sparks a fire throws up: the individual minds are so many “scintillations” of the dominant mind that controls them. Vijnanabhikshu cites the case the mind of the epic hero Rama: although he was the incarnation of the omniscient god Vishnu, his individual “human” mind nonetheless remained unaware of his inherent divinity. †

Hariharananda Aranya uses the example of a hypnotist. Just as the magician’s mind acts on the minds of his spectators to produce mass hypnosis, so the yogi’s dominant mind controls the secondary minds in the bodies he has created. For Aranya, these verses further suggest the way that Ishvara, the fully liberated “Master of Yoga,” could use his created mind to “favor those who are qualified for liberation” at the end of a cosmic cycle. In a similar vein, Vachaspati Mishra and Vijnanabhikshu both quote a verse from the Puranas, which states that “by virtue of his authoritative power, the Ishvara, though one, becomes many. Then being many he becomes one. And from him also proceed all these variations of consciousness.”¹⁴ Both also quote a passage from the *Mahabharata*, which describes human masters of yoga as creating or taking over multiple bodies, using some to enjoy the pleasures of the world and others to practice asceticism. All of these may be drawn back into the yogi’s own body and mind “like the sun does with its rays of light.” †

The power of the yogi to create, take over, and control other bodies and minds was universally accepted, not only among Yoga philosophers but also in nearly †

every philosophical school, religious sect, and written tradition of medieval India. Exponents of Nyaya-Vaisheshika philosophy, the great Advaita Vedanta philosopher Shankara, as well as a variety of Shaivas, Buddhists, and Jains all assumed that these yogic powers were real. A rich mythology predating the *Yoga Sutra*, and going back to the Hindu *Mahabharata* and *Maitri Upanishad* and the Buddhist *Vimuttimaggā*, portrayed yogis in these roles, and commentators cited these and other sources as scriptural precedents for their philosophical analyses. Some applied the principles set forth in these three sutras to resolve philosophical conundrums found in other works. How, for example, could Krishna assert in the *Bhagavad Gita* (4.37) that through the practice of Yoga, one's "fire of knowledge" would instantaneously burn away the karma accumulated in thousands of previous lives? Because, as the ninth-century Nyaya philosopher Vyomaśhiva explained, a yogi could use all the minds in all the bodies he had created or appropriated as a great karma-burning machine. Vivekananda—who did not wish to remind his readers of the links between the *Yoga Sutra* and India's yogis, and who, following the Neo-Vedanta strategy of employing his own powers of reason over and against commentarial convention—placed his own authority above his august predecessors and misappropriated these verses into a late nineteenth-century sermon on evolutionary theory.

By using the methods of European classicists, Henry Thomas Colebrooke recovered the *Yoga Sutra* from

oblivion and made its content known to the nascent field of Western Indology. By adopting the teachings of the Puranas and pandits, and by using the methods and concepts of European and American spiritualists, Swami Vivekananda recovered the *Yoga Sutra* from oblivion and made its content known to the milieus of Western spiritualism. Over the past century, Vivekananda's legacy has prevailed in the yoga subculture, where teachers continue to confuse Yoga philosophy with Puranic, Hatha, and Tantric doctrines; to present Western metaphysical and scientistic concepts in Indian trappings; to identify Yoga as a healing tradition; to assert the scientific foundations of Yoga; and to present Raja as the highest form of Yoga. If, to again quote Mark Singleton, "the vision of the *Yoga Sutra* as the source of a timeless tradition of Classical Indian Yoga is but an *idée reçue* of the modern era,"¹⁵ there † can be no doubt that Vivekananda was its primary transmitter.